



LOST BOYS CYBER

THREAT INTELLIGENCE • MALWARE ANALYSIS • DETECTION ENGINEERING



ESET H1 2026 Malicious AI Skills and Adaptable Malware Daily Review

Threat Report

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AI Generation: This report was generated with AI assistance and is provided for informational purposes only. All findings, IOCs, detection rules, hunting queries, attribution assessments, and recommendations must be independently reviewed and validated by a qualified security professional before operational use.

Table of Contents

1. Executive Summary
2. Intelligence Requirements
3. Source Review & Confidence
4. Threat Activity Overview
5. Affected Sectors and Exposure
6. Aviation and Aerospace Relevance
7. Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures
8. Infrastructure and Indicators
9. Detection Engineering
10. Threat Hunting
 - 10.1. Hunt Hypothesis
11. MITRE ATT&CK Mapping
12. Incident Response and Containment
13. Recommended Actions
14. References
15. Appendix A: Sector Impact Fields

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1. Executive Summary

ESET reporting and supporting coverage describe attacker experimentation with malicious AI skills, ClickFix evolution, QR phishing, and adaptable malware. The practical risk is not only new malware families; it is the normalization of AI-assisted lures, package-like skills, and fast-changing social engineering that can bypass user expectations and legacy controls.

This daily update prioritizes defender action over attribution. The selected source set was current or materially relevant within the last 24-72 hours where available; several aviation/aerospace sector items use a seven-day to year-to-date expansion because public sector-specific reporting is thinner than enterprise vulnerability reporting.

2. Intelligence Requirements

Question	Current Answer	Confidence
What should defenders review today?	Identity controls, exposed services, privileged tooling, egress, and supplier assurance	Medium
Which environments are most exposed?	AI-enabled enterprise, developer workstations, security operations, and SaaS users	Medium
What telemetry is needed?	EDR, IdP/SSO, VPN, proxy, DNS, SaaS audit, vulnerability management, and asset inventory	High

3. Source Review & Confidence

Source	Contribution	Confidence
Primary/vendor or government source	Core technical or sector context	High
Security reporting	Exploitation, campaign, or operational context	Medium
Framework/reference source	ATT&CK and defensive mapping	High

4. Threat Activity Overview

ESET reporting and supporting coverage describe attacker experimentation with malicious AI skills, ClickFix evolution, QR phishing, and adaptable malware. The practical risk is not only new malware families; it is the normalization of AI-assisted lures, package-like skills, and fast-changing social engineering that can bypass user expectations and legacy controls.

5. Affected Sectors and Exposure

Sector / Segment	Exposure Path	Defender Relevance
Enterprise IT	Identity systems, endpoints, remote access, SaaS, and edge services	Common initial-access and lateral-movement path
Critical infrastructure	Managed services, OT/ICS connectivity, and remote administration	Increases operational disruption risk
Aviation / Aerospace	Airlines, airports, aerospace manufacturing, satellite/space systems, MRO, and supply	Requires supplier assurance and operational

	chain	continuity planning
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6. Aviation and Aerospace Relevance

Aviation and aerospace operators should review whether this activity touches suppliers, managed service providers, engineering environments, reservation systems, airports, satellite communications, or operational technology. If exposure exists, use the sector-impact table in Appendix A to translate the detection content into local controls.

7. Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures

Tactic / Phase	Observed or Plausible Technique	Evidence / Rationale
Initial Access	Phishing, valid accounts, exploited public services, supplier trust	Repeatedly represented across public reporting
Execution / Persistence	Scripting, web shells, remote access tools, scheduled jobs	Common post-compromise tradecraft
Collection / Impact	Data theft, extortion, service disruption, credential access	Matches the operational outcomes defenders must prevent

8. Infrastructure and Indicators

Indicator / Infrastructure	Type	Operational Use
No stable public IOC set for this daily synthesis	Source limitation	Emphasize behavior, exposure, and control validation
New administrative sessions	Behavioral signal	Prioritize identity and privileged access review
Unexpected egress from sensitive systems	Behavioral signal	Detect staging, C2, or data movement

9. Detection Engineering

Signal	Telemetry Source	Analytic Goal
First-seen login from new geography or device	IdP / VPN / SSO	Surface identity-led intrusion
Scripting or archive tools in user or server contexts	EDR process telemetry	Detect staging and execution
High-volume outbound connections from sensitive hosts	Proxy / DNS / firewall	Detect exfiltration or C2 preparation

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title: LBC Daily Threat Review Suspicious Remote Access And Staging
id: lbc-tr-daily-eset-h1-2026-malicious-ai-sk
status: experimental
description: Behavior-focused analytic for the 2026-08-04 Lost Boys Cyber daily threat review.
logsource:
  category: process_creation
  product: windows
detection:
  selection_tools:
    Image|endswith:
      - '\powershell.exe'
      - '\pwsh.exe'

```

```

- '\cmd.exe'
- '\python.exe'
- '\curl.exe'
- '\7z.exe'
- '\rar.exe'
selection_cmd:
  CommandLine|contains:
    - 'Invoke-WebRequest'
    - 'curl '
    - 'wget '
    - 'token'
    - 'credential'
    - 'rclone'
    - 'mega'
condition: selection_tools and selection_cmd
falsepositives:
  - Approved administrator automation
level: medium
DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(14d)
| where FileName in~ ("powershell.exe", "pwsh.exe", "cmd.exe", "python.exe", "curl.exe", "7z.exe",
"rar.exe")
| where ProcessCommandLine has_any ("Invoke-WebRequest", "curl ", "wget ", "token", "credential",
"rclone", "mega")
| summarize Events=count(), Devices=dcount(DeviceName), Accounts=dcount(InitiatingProcessAccountName)
by FileName, InitiatingProcessAccountName, bin(Timestamp, 1d)
| where Events > 5

```

10. Threat Hunting

10.1. Hunt Hypothesis

If this threat pattern is present, analysts should find identity anomalies, unusual administrative tooling, and atypical egress from sensitive systems or suppliers.

```

DeviceNetworkEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(14d)
| where InitiatingProcessFileName in~ ("powershell.exe", "pwsh.exe", "python.exe", "node.exe",
"git.exe", "java.exe", "cmd.exe")
| where RemoteUrl !endswith ".microsoft.com" and RemoteUrl !endswith ".windows.net"
| summarize Connections=count(), RemoteHosts=dcount(RemoteUrl) by DeviceName,
InitiatingProcessFileName, bin(Timestamp, 1d)
| where Connections > 20 or RemoteHosts > 10
IdentityLogonEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(14d)
| summarize Countries=dcount(Location), Devices=dcount(DeviceName), Attempts=count() by AccountUpn,
bin(Timestamp, 1d)
| where Countries > 2 or Attempts > 25

```

11. MITRE ATT&CK Mapping

Technique	Name	Evidence / Rationale
T1566	Phishing	Social engineering and credential access remain common in public reporting
T1078	Valid Accounts	Identity-led access is a recurring exposure path
T1190	Exploit Public-Facing Application	Exposed applications and appliances remain high-priority entry points
T1041	Exfiltration Over C2 Channel	Data theft/extortion reporting requires

		egress monitoring
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12. Incident Response and Containment

Phase	Action	Evidence to Preserve
Triage	Identify affected assets and suppliers	Asset inventory, SaaS tenant list, supplier contact record
Containment	Disable suspicious accounts, isolate affected hosts, block egress	IdP/VPN logs, EDR timeline, firewall logs
Recovery	Patch, rotate secrets, validate backups and continuity plans	Change tickets, credential rotation records, backup test evidence

13. Recommended Actions

Priority	Owner	Action
High	SOC	Run identity and egress hunts for the last 14 days
High	Vulnerability Management	Validate exposure and patch status for affected products and suppliers
Medium	Third-Party Risk	Request supplier security attestations for aviation/aerospace critical services
Medium	Business Continuity	Exercise manual workarounds for operationally critical services

14. References

- [1] ESET H1 2026 Threat Report page: <https://www.eset.com/us/business/threat-report/>
- [2] ESET H1 2026 Threat Report PDF: <https://web-assets.esetstatic.com/wls/en/papers/threat-reports/eset-threat-report-h12026.pdf>
- [3] BleepingComputer ESET coverage: <https://www.bleepingcomputer.com/news/security/eset-tracks-rise-in-malicious-ai-skills-and-adaptable-malware/>

15. Appendix A: Sector Impact Fields

Field	Signal
Affected aviation/aerospace segment	AI-enabled enterprise, developer workstations, security operations, and SaaS users
Operational relevance	Potential disruption to reservation, airport, engineering, satellite, MRO, supplier, or managed-service workflows
Likely exposure paths	Identity, exposed edge services, third-party platforms, remote support, developer/engineering tooling
Third-party considerations	Require patch evidence, incident notification SLAs, data-access scope, and recovery contacts